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Article

What Else Moved?

Sue Broughton

Gaia Nexus Online

August 27, 2026

Why the consequences of AI optimisation may appear somewhere else in the organisation — and years later

Today, three apparently separate conversations made me think about AI investment in a different way.

The first concerned productivity.

If AI removes thousands of hours of work, what happens to the capacity it releases?

The second concerned organisational capability.

If AI removes some of the work through which people historically developed judgement, when and where does that loss eventually appear?

And the third came from an extraordinary example involving Antoni Gaudí, gravity, string and an upside down church.

Together, they suggest a question that may be missing from the way organisations measure AI:

When we change one part of the system, what else moves?

Gaudí's upside down church

Mo Johnson recently shared the story of the hanging models Antoni Gaudí used in designing the Colònia Güell church and elements of the Sagrada Família.

Gaudí suspended cords and attached weights representing the loads the finished structure would carry.

Gravity pulled the cords into their natural configuration.

Turn the model upside down and those curves provided the structural geometry Gaudí needed.

But there is a detail that matters for our purposes.

Move one anchor point and the rest of the model resettles.

The intervention does not remain local.

Forces redistribute.

Relationships change.

The configuration responds.

The consequence becomes visible in the behaviour of the whole structure.

Mo described Gaudí's conceptual shift particularly well: rather than continuing to ask how to calculate the answer, Gaudí asked what conditions could produce it.

That made me wonder whether there is an organisational equivalent.

Because an enterprise introducing AI is also changing loads within a connected system.

But we often measure the result as though the point we changed were independent of everything around it.

AI looks local on a dashboard

Imagine AI is introduced into a customer service operation.

Response times fall by 30%.

Excellent.

Or an AI system automates part of a finance process and releases 10,000 employee hours.

Excellent.

Or software development accelerates significantly.

Again, excellent.

Each measure may be completely accurate.

But the organisation is not a collection of independent points.

The customer service improvement may increase exception handling elsewhere.

The finance automation may increase assurance and review requirements.

Faster software development may increase the volume of work reaching security, testing or governance functions.

AI may remove production work while creating verification work.

It may reduce the number of people required to perform a process while concentrating the difficult exceptions among a smaller number of highly experienced people.

It may accelerate decisions while increasing the burden on the humans responsible for deciding when those decisions should not be trusted.

The important question therefore isn't only:

What improved?

It is:

What else moved when it improved?

Work does not always disappear

This is particularly important when organisations calculate AI productivity.

Suppose AI removes 1,000 hours of work.

Those hours have genuinely been released.

But imagine that elsewhere in the organisation another 250 hours are now being spent checking outputs, investigating anomalies, handling exceptions, tracing evidence and resolving cases the AI cannot safely complete.

The original productivity calculation is not necessarily wrong.

AI really did remove 1,000 hours from the original process.

But from an enterprise perspective, some of the work has changed **form, location and ownership**.

That distinction matters.

If we measure only where the intervention occurred, AI can appear to have removed demand that has actually been redistributed through the organisation.

And workload is only one thing capable of moving.

Judgement can move too

Brad Wolfe recently gave another example, but across a much longer time horizon.

As AI removes or compresses work, it may also remove some of the experiences through which people historically developed judgement.

The productivity benefit appears immediately.

The capability consequence may take years to become visible.

Brad translated that delayed consequence into something a board can understand.

Eventually the organisation needs to fill a senior position.

Nobody internally is ready.

The company hires externally, pays a premium and takes considerably longer to fill the position.

The original capability loss has finally acquired an economic label.

Brad calls this **the hiring invoice**.

What makes this example so interesting is that the eventual problem appears somewhere quite different from the original intervention.

The original dashboard may have shown:

Productivity ↑

Years later another dashboard shows:

Internal senior capability ↓

Then:

External recruitment ↑

Time to fill ↑

Cost ↑

Those may be treated as separate management problems.

But what if they are partly different points on the same organisational pathway?

The consequence can move through time

That introduces another difficulty.

Redistribution does not necessarily happen immediately.

Some effects appear within days.

AI generates more exceptions and review workload rises.

Some appear within months.

Experienced employees increasingly become bottlenecks because difficult cases are concentrating around them.

Others may take years.

The developmental experiences that once produced future senior capability gradually disappear.

By the time internal fill rates reveal the problem, much of the pathway that produced the capability may already have been eroding for years. Brad explicitly proposed tracking the trend in internal fill rates as an imperfect but commercially discussable measure; in our subsequent exchange, I suggested pairing that lagging measure with earlier signals showing whether the experiences through which capability forms still exist.

So the management problem becomes more difficult.

The place where value is created may not be the place where cost appears.

And:

The time when the benefit appears may not be the time when the consequence appears.

Eventually the organisation can become the constraint

This brings us back to another observation from Mo Johnson in response to my recent article on AI savings:

“released capacity and retained value are two different things, especially when the organization itself becomes the constraint.”

That distinction becomes increasingly important as AI capability scales.

AI may be capable of processing another million transactions.

But can the organisation absorb the resulting exceptions?

Can assurance functions absorb the additional verification?

Can experienced people absorb the difficult cases?

Can governance functions keep pace?

Can humans still intervene effectively?

Can the organisation recover when something behaves unexpectedly?

And does it still possess the internal capability required to govern what it has automated?

At some point the constraint on AI value may no longer be what the technology can do.

It may be **what the surrounding organisation can absorb**.

This changes how we think about capacity

Apparently unused capacity is often treated as inefficiency.

But some organisational capacity exists precisely because systems do not operate under average conditions all the time.

Demand spikes.

Exceptions cluster.

People leave.

Systems fail.

Unexpected cases appear.

Decisions need reconsidering.

AI creates circumstances its designers did not anticipate.

The organisation needs somewhere for those loads to go.

That means spare capacity can sometimes perform a function similar to structural headroom.

Remove too much of it and the organisation may become extremely efficient under normal conditions while increasingly fragile under abnormal ones.

The same principle applies to human capability.

A senior person's apparently underutilised expertise may look expensive until the exceptional case arrives.

A review function may appear inefficient until AI activity doubles.

A developmental assignment may look like work that can easily be automated until the organisation discovers that nobody acquired the judgement that assignment used to produce.

What looks inefficient locally may be contributing to resilience globally.

Gaudí gives us another way of seeing the problem

This is why I keep returning to the hanging model.

Gaudí did not need to calculate every relationship independently and then hope he had captured the whole structure.

The relationships themselves revealed what happened when conditions changed.

Move the load.

Move an anchor.

The configuration responds.

Perhaps organisations need to become better at observing AI in the same way.

Not simply:

Did this implementation achieve its KPI?

But:

What changed around it when it did?

Did verification demand rise?

Did expert workload concentrate?

Did escalation behaviour change?

Did human participation decline?

Did authority migrate?

Did dependency increase?

Did recovery capacity change?

Did developmental opportunities disappear?

Did apparently unused capacity become more important?

Did another function move closer to saturation?

And critically:

Are we seeing those movements early enough to do something about them?

From isolated metrics to organisational configuration

This is one of the problems I believe **Coherence Centric Governance (CCG)** can help make visible.

CCG is not intended to replace financial, operational or performance measures with an abstract measure of "coherence."

Those measures remain essential.

The problem is that they frequently describe individual parts of a system.

CCG asks what is happening **between those parts as conditions change**.

An AI intervention changes utilisation.

Work redistributes.

Human participation changes.

Verification demand changes.

Judgement formation may change.

Authority may shift.

Dependency can increase or decrease.

Recovery capacity may strengthen or weaken.

The organisation moves into a different configuration.

The purpose is not to declare that every change is harmful.

Quite the opposite.

An intervention might improve one domain and strengthen the wider organisation.

Or a productivity improvement might create additional demand elsewhere that the organisation has ample capacity to absorb.

Making the redistribution visible can therefore support scaling, not merely constrain it.

The important point is that we should know.

An intervention can improve the domain in which it is introduced while changing the wider system through the redistribution it causes elsewhere.

That is difficult to see when every metric is examined independently.

The next investment decision

Imagine a company has successfully deployed AI.

Productivity increased.

Costs fell.

Customer response improved.

Management is now considering the next major AI investment.

The conventional question is:

Did the first investment work?

The answer may quite legitimately be yes.

But perhaps another question belongs beside it:

What else moved?

What work disappeared?

What work appeared?

Where did it appear?

What human capability became more important?

What capability became less practised?

Where did demand concentrate?

Which functions moved closer to their limits?

What apparently unused capacity turned out to have a purpose?

What dependencies increased?

And which consequences have not yet had enough time to become visible?

Only then can management ask the question that really matters:

What is likely to move if we scale again?

The organisation is the system

The temptation with AI is to treat the technology as the system and the organisation as the environment into which it is deployed.

Increasingly, I think that distinction is inadequate.

The people reviewing outputs are part of the operating system.

The experts handling exceptions are part of it.

The managers exercising judgement are part of it.

The governance functions establishing boundaries are part of it.

The developmental pathways producing tomorrow's capability are part of it.

So are the reserves of capacity that allow the organisation to absorb what happens when conditions depart from the average.

AI changes that configuration.

Sometimes dramatically.

And the consequences may not appear where we expect them.

Gaudí's strings make the principle wonderfully visible.

Move one point and the structure resettles.

Perhaps that should become one of the questions we ask about AI investment too.

Not simply:

What did the AI improve?

But:

What else moved?

Because the most consequential effect of an AI investment may eventually appear somewhere completely different from where the investment was made.

And sometimes, years later.

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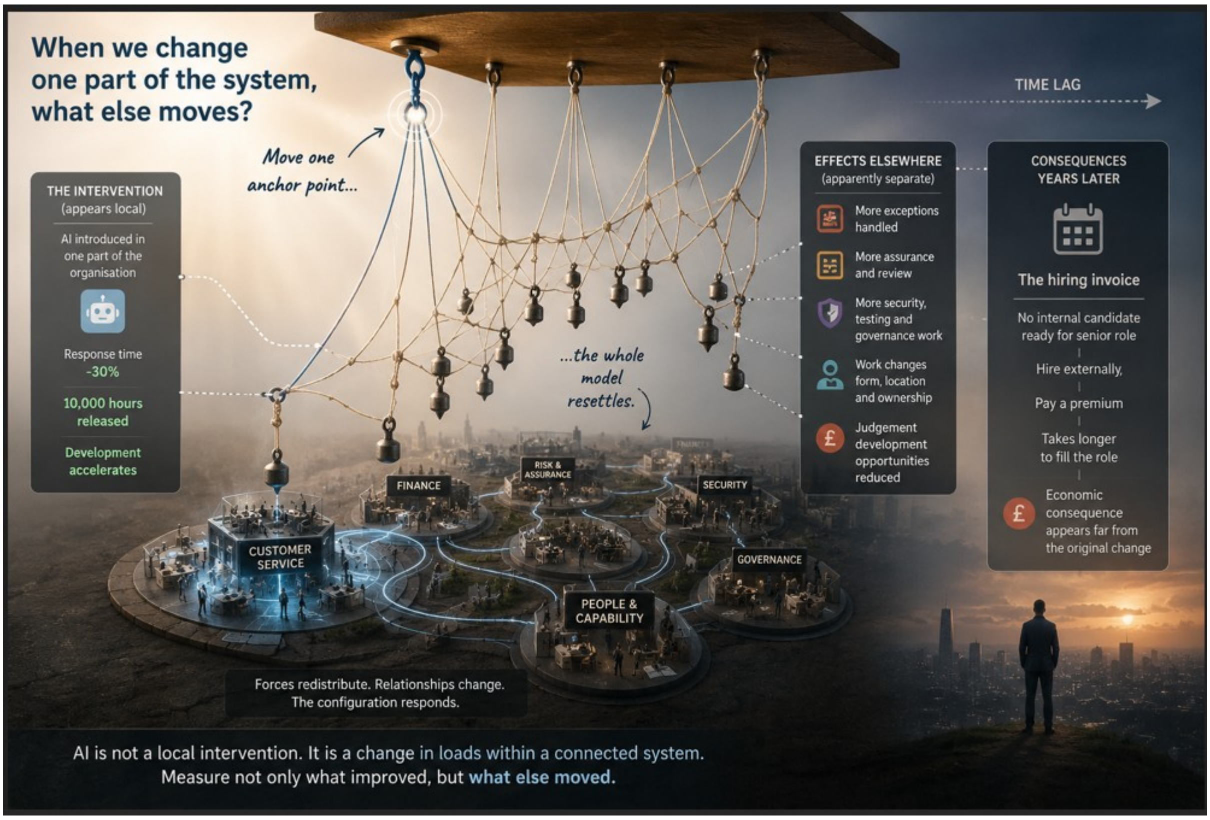
*My thanks to **[Mo Johnson]**, whose post on Antoni Gaudí's hanging models provided the structural analogy behind this article, and whose subsequent observation that the organisation itself can become the constraint helped connect that analogy to AI scaling.*

*My thanks also to **[Brad Wolfe](#)**, whose "hiring invoice" translated delayed capability loss into a tangible economic consequence and helped expose the importance of looking for effects that emerge elsewhere and later.*

And to Justin Jauss, whose observation about the growing human verification burden around AI helped sharpen the distinction between work that disappears and work that changes form, location and ownership.

Image



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Post

AI can improve exactly what we asked it to improve and still change something important somewhere else.

A customer service system gets faster.
A finance process releases thousands of hours.
Software development accelerates.
The dashboard says the AI worked.
But organisations are connected systems.

Work can move rather than disappear. Verification demand can rise elsewhere. Expert workload can concentrate. Developmental pathways can weaken. And some consequences may not become visible until years after the original productivity gain.

Antoni Gaudí's extraordinary hanging models offer a useful way to think about this.

Move one anchor point and the whole structure resettles.
Perhaps we need to look at AI investment the same way.

Not only:
What did the AI improve?

But:
What else moved?

And before we scale again:
What is likely to move next?

In this article, I explore what that could mean for AI productivity, organisational capacity, human capability and Coherence Centric Governance.

With thanks to Mo Johnson, Brad Wolfe and Justin Jauss, whose different observations helped bring the pieces of this question together.

Full article attached

hashtag#ArtificialIntelligence **hashtag#AIGovernance** **hashtag#AIAgents** **hashtag#AITransformation** **hashtag#HumanAI** **hashtag#OrganisationalDesign** **hashtag#FutureOfWork** **hashtag#AIOperations** **hashtag#CoherenceCentricGovernance** **hashtag#GaiaNexus**

Discussion

RAVI SHANKAR NRK • 1stPremium • 1st

COO · Head of Operations & Strategy · P&L Leader | Scaled SBU 2.5x to ₹108 Cr ($13M) in 12 months | Target Operating Model · Lean Six Sigma · Cross-Functional Leadership | ex-Commander, Indian Navy

4h

The ultimate question your article forces us to confront is not just “What else moved?” but “When the system resettles, will the organization still possess the structural integrity to hold the weight, or has AI quietly dissolved the very anchors that kept it standing?”
Would be very interested in your thoughts on how CCG moves from observing the "between" to actively governing it. (4/4)

Like

1

Reply3 replies3 Replies on RAVI SHANKAR NRK’s comment

See previous replies

Sue Broughton Premium**Author**

Gaia Nexus Online

2h

3 / 3
RAVI SHANKAR NRK What appears as inefficiency on one dashboard may then become a defensible resilience requirement when its relationship to the wider system is visible.

So perhaps I would slightly change your final question.

Not: how does CCG govern the between?
But: how does CCG make the between governable?

For me, that preserves an important boundary. CCG observes and reports material changes in the conditions surrounding the system; it does not become the authority that decides what the organisation must do about them.

And your final image of the anchors is exactly the longitudinal question I think the Gaudí analogy ultimately raises. The concern isn't only whether the organisation can carry today's redistributed load. It is whether repeated optimisation is progressively changing the very capacities on which tomorrow's resilience, judgement and governing authority depend.

Thank you for pushing the argument this far. Your questions have helped make the boundary considerably clearer.

Like

Reply

11 impressions

Ranganath Raghavan • 1stPremium • 1st

Executive Advisor & Growth Leader | Human Judgment, Leadership & Organizational Complexity in the Age of AI | Helping Leaders Navigate Uncertainty with Clarity

21h

AI removes the work, but it also removes the training ground. Companies will spend the next decade paying massive recruiter fees just to import the judgment they forgot to build internally.

Like

2

Reply1 reply1 Comment on Ranganath Raghavan’s comment

Sue Broughton PremiumAuthor

Gaia Nexus Online

21h

Ranganath Raghavan Exactly, Ranganath. And I think training ground is the critical phrase.
The productivity gain is visible immediately, the loss of the conditions through which judgement develops may remain invisible for years.

By the time the organisation discovers it has to import that judgement externally, the recruitment cost is only the visible invoice. The deeper problem is that the internal pathway that once produced the capability has already weakened.

That is why I think we need to measure not only the capability an organisation has today, but whether the experiences that produce tomorrow's capability still exist.

Like

3

Reply

24 impressions

Minas Papagiannopoulos • 1stVerified • 1st

Adaptive Systems — Runtime Qualification, Interpretation, and State

15h

Sue, the Gaudí analogy also seems to expose an attribution boundary. In the hanging model, the relationship between a moved anchor and the resettled configuration is physically continuous and directly observable. In an organisation, longitudinal observation may show that workload, judgment formation, or recovery capacity changed after an AI intervention without by itself establishing that the intervention caused each movement. So perhaps “what else moved?” needs to remain paired with “what relationship does the available evidence entitle us to establish between that movement and the intervention?”
Otherwise the system view may correct the narrowness of local measurement while quietly acquiring more causal authority than the evidence supports.

…more

Like

1

Reply1 reply1 Comment on Minas Papagiannopoulos’ comment

Sue Broughton Premium**Author**

Gaia Nexus Online

10h

Minas Papagiannopoulos Minas, yes I think that boundary is essential. What else moved? should widen the field of observation, not widen the causal authority of the evidence. Longitudinal observation may establish that a change occurred, when it occurred, how it developed and whether it coincided with an intervention. None of those observations alone establishes that the intervention caused the change. Perhaps that gives us another useful separation:
Detection → association → attribution

CCG may detect movement that a predefined control architecture was not designed to observe. It may also accumulate enough longitudinal evidence to establish relationships worth investigating. But causal attribution should require its own evidentiary threshold rather than being inherited from the fact that the movement was detected.

That seems especially important in organisations because multiple interventions, incentives, workloads and environmental changes are occurring simultaneously.

So I agree What else moved? must remain paired with What does the evidence actually entitle us to say about why it moved?
Otherwise we solve one governance problem, observational narrowness by creating another, causal overreach.

Like

1

Reply

7 impressions

N . G . Z . • 1st1st

Audit & Regulatory Verification Consultant | Data Integrity | Enterprise Risk & Compliance Frameworks

20h

Sue, your application of Gaudí’s catenary equilibrium to enterprise AI deployment is brilliant. When local throughput accelerates, structural tension instantly redistributes into unmitigated verification debt and algorithmic drift.

From an enterprise risk and audit perspective, Coherence-Centric Governance cannot rely solely on post-hoc observation of "what moved." It requires a deterministic data integrity framework embedded directly into the architecture before shifting operational anchor points. Without continuous, multi-layered verification, local efficiency is simply unhedged systemic risk.

Celebrate

2

Reply1 reply1 Comment on N . G . Z .’s comment

Sue Broughton PremiumAuthor

Gaia Nexus Online

20h

N . G . Z . Thank you and I agree that deterministic integrity and verification controls need to exist before operational anchor points are shifted.

Where I would add a distinction is that I don't see CCG as relying on post hoc observation. Some redistribution needs to be anticipated and bounded architecturally; other effects only become knowable as the organisation changes around the intervention.

A deterministic framework may verify whether specified conditions continue to hold, but it may not tell us that expert workload is concentrating elsewhere, developmental pathways are weakening, human judgement is becoming less practised, or another organisational function is moving towards saturation.

So perhaps we need both: controls that protect the anchor points we already know matter, and longitudinal observation capable of detecting what begins to move between them. The interesting governance problem for me is the interaction between the two.

Like

1

Reply

19 impressions

RAVI SHANKAR NRK • 1stPremium • 1st

COO · Head of Operations & Strategy · P&L Leader | Scaled SBU 2.5x to ₹108 Cr ($13M) in 12 months | Target Operating Model · Lean Six Sigma · Cross-Functional Leadership | ex-Commander, Indian Navy

4h

Sue, this is a deeply insightful piece. The concept of the "hiring invoice" perfectly crystallizes the delayed, invisible costs of AI optimization, and using Gaudí’s hanging model to illustrate systemic redistribution is masterful.
However, if we push the analogy and the logic to their limits, they raise several sharp operational and structural questions that a governance model must answer:
1. Organizations are not passive to gravity.
Gaudí’s model is a closed physical system governed by passive forces. When you move an anchor, the strings must resettle. Organizations, however, are active, adaptive systems. When AI redistributes the "load" of exceptions to human experts, humans don’t just passively absorb the weight until they snap. They invent new shadow processes, they rubber-stamp AI outputs to clear queues (automation bias), or they quit. The question isn't just “what moved?” but “what maladaptive behavior did the system invent to disguise the fact that it was overloaded?” (1/4)

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4h

2. The subtractive bias of judgment.
The article assumes AI simply removes the experiences through which people develop judgment. But what if AI changes the nature of judgment required? If a junior analyst is no longer reviewing basic transactions but is suddenly handling 5x the volume of high-complexity edge cases, are they not developing judgment—just a different, faster kind? If the "hiring invoice" eventually arrives, is it because judgment was destroyed or because the organization failed to redefine the seniority pathway for this new type of cognitive work?
3. The economics of "structural headroom."
You rightly note that "spare capacity" acts as structural headroom against abnormal conditions. But in a world where CFOs and activist investors actively hunt for "inefficiency," how do we defend that headroom? If a governance model cannot quantify the ROI of "apparently unused capacity," that capacity will be stripped out by financial optimization before the next exception cluster arrives. How does Coherence Centric Governance (CCG) put a defensible dollar value on organizational slack? (2/4)

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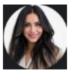
4h

4. CCG and the Telemetry of "Between."
You state that CCG asks what is happening between the parts. But

traditional dashboards are built on local metrics. What is the actual telemetry for CCG? How does an enterprise technically measure "dependency increase" or "judgment erosion" before the hiring invoice arrives? If we cannot instrument these movements in near-real-time, CCG remains a post-mortem concept rather than a governing tool.
5. The constraint of runtime enforcement.
You ask, "Can humans still intervene effectively? ... Can the organization recover when something behaves unexpectedly?" This touches the absolute boundary of AI governance. If AI is operating at machine speed, human intervention is no longer a viable control; it is a myth. When the "unexpected" happens, the organization cannot wait for a human to resettle the load. The architecture itself must structurally contain the failure. (3/4)

Like

Reply



Emma Shad • 2ndPremium • 2nd

CEO@Emellex AI | #1 Most Followed Voice AI Growth and Business | Publisher, LinkedIn Today | Founder, AI Leadership Hub |Creator, Silicon Valley Today |Helping Founders, Executives, Investors &Tech Brands Build Authority

13h

This is a brilliant analogy, Sue! 🎯 How are others identifying those subtle, downstream impacts of AI implementations in their organizations? 🤔

Like

1

Reply1 reply1 Comment on Emma Shad’s comment

Sue Broughton Premium**Author**

Gaia Nexus Online

10h

Emma Shad Emma, that is really the challenge. Some organisations are getting better at monitoring known downstream effects through operational, financial and risk metrics, but the harder problem is detecting consequences that were not specified when the AI intervention was designed.

That is why I think longitudinal observation matters. If workload moves from production into verification, expert judgement becomes concentrated in fewer people, exception handling grows elsewhere, or developmental opportunities progressively disappear, no single KPI may initially identify the change as an AI consequence.
The organisation needs to be able to ask not only Did the AI deliver the intended improvement? but What else changed as a result of introducing it?

And as Minas has rightly raised elsewhere in this discussion, detecting that something moved is not the same as proving what caused it. That attribution still needs evidence. For me, that combination, wider observation without causal overreach, is where this becomes particularly interesting.

Like

Reply

8 impressions